

ds the company.

As an example, GitLab Commit · a series of user conferences · doubles as an excellent mechanism to bring colleagues together for a purpose, while also serving the greater community.

Annual (or regular) summits

{{< youtube "xdtPNXtkBhE" >}}

GitLab Contribute 2019 recap reel.

While virtual events and ongoing touch points through informal communication mechanisms are vital for a team's growth, all-remote companies should consider a regularly scheduled gathering or summit for the entire company.

These gatherings should be optional, though encouraged, and should focus primarily on bonding. Hosting a summit only to inundate colleagues with presentations is not recommended. At GitLab Contribute, for example, numerous excursions are planned throughout the week in order to bring people together in the same physical space for non-work activities.

With no central office, these are remarkably flexible. Your company may choose a different location for each occurrence, or perhaps support a voting system where colleagues can offer up suggestions for ideal locations.

In all-remote settings, these known touch points are critical for morale. Team members can plan their year around these seminal moments, with a period of in-person experiences giving them fresh perspective when engaging in the future through Zoom or phone.

Holidays, celebrations, and local coworking days

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{{% card footer="Celebrations at GitLab Commit London 2019" %}}

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As an all-remote team scales, you may find that certain regions of the world are home to multiple team members. At GitLab, we encourage colleagues to join Location Channels in Slack, which allow them to easily connect with others who live relatively nearby.

This creates an easy path for gathering in a central location to bond. Common reasons for scheduling a get-together are holidays and milestone celebrations, though active local communities may consider coming together on a regular basis (monthly, quarterly, etc.) simply to maintain a physical connection.

Being a 100% remote company creates unique opportunities for these gatherings. A team may consider rotating who picks the venue or locale to meet at, creating a diverse calendar of events. Those who are comfortable doing so may even consider inviting local team members to their home or neighborhood.

GitLab recognizes that not everyone can or will prefer to work from their home. In turn, fees associated with co-working spaces are reimbursable. Through location channels, team members who live close to one another can easily arrange dedicated co-working days and shared events, covering everything from dining together to supporting a local charity as a unit.

Subsidized travel to visit team members

{{< youtube "KXHwEGlqI-Y" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (GitLab) and Elisa (The Cowork Experience) discuss the merits of a company subsidizing and encouraging travel to visit other colleagues.

Savings on real estate · and the litany of associated costs with operating one or more offices · is a key financial reason for a company to organize itself as completely remote. Consider returning some of those savings to employees by subsidizing travel costs associated with visiting colleagues around the globe.

GitLab's Visiting Grant incentive is one such example. While some colleagues may prefer to stay put, there is value in transparently encouraging colleagues to spend time with one another in a physical space. When a colleague travels to visit someone else, they are immersed in a new place and new culture, which leads to greater empathy and understanding.

This also reinforces a company's ability to create a more geographically diverse and inclusive work environment.

Coworking excursions and retreats

{{< youtube "aJobgAOCW84" >}}

The Cowork Experience assists remote companies with planning excursions that bring colleagues together in the same physical space.

As an all-remote company scales, it becomes more challenging to get the entire company in one place during the same window of time. As the once-a-year company annual becomes a standard offering (and less a differentiator) for remote companies, there is opportunity to host smaller, more frequent excursions and retreats.

The Cowork Experience, for instance, develops bespoke programs with more intimate engagements at the team or regional level to foster deeper trust amongst colleagues. These usually include team-building activities as well as non-work excursions. They present an opportunity to bring colleagues together in a unique, refreshing locale, catalyzing things like planning while enabling personal bonds to be built.

Leadership should be mindful of personal strain placed on team members when they are asked to leave their home for extended periods of time, with covered childcare or similar assistance ensuring that undue burdens are not placed on caregivers.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Considerations for in-person interactions in a remote company

Anyone can test their knowledge on considerations for in-person interactions in a remote

company by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/informal-communication.md

On this page, we're detailing how informal communication occurs at GitLab, how it complements in-person interactions, and why it matters in an all-remote culture. There are over 20 different ways to foster informal communication below, and we are constantly discovering and adding new methods.

What do we mean by informal communication?

Informal communication in the workplace is made up of interactions between co-workers that are unofficial in nature and focus on building social relationships outside of the normal hierarchy of a typical business structure.

In other words, it's what happens when we get to know each other and talk about anything other than work.

Talking about the weather; sharing photos of pets, favorite foods or holidays; sending a birthday greeting or encouraging message; banter, chit-chat, and having a laugh - it's all part of bringing our full selves to work.

What is the difference between formal and informal communication in the workplace?

Since GitLab is an all-remote organization that works asynchronously, nearly all work communication is documented, making all work-related communications "formal" communications. This helps support our value of transparency.

We are big on relationship-building. We highly value intentionally creating time to build relationships via informal communications.

Why is informal communication so important in a remote work setting?

Informal communication builds an informal substructure of trust. This trust helps people accept decisions. That acceptance makes successful execution of decision more likely.

All-remote workers who are all-work all the time risk loneliness or burnout. One of the best ways to combat loneliness and burnout are through relationship-building by prioritizing regular social interactions via informal communication throughout the workday, week, and month.

Informal communication advantages and disadvantages

While some people thrive on spending time to get to know others, others are annoyed by non-work-related texts and messages. Informal communication among diverse team members requires a high level of empathy.

It's helpful to be transparent about your communication preferences so managers and teammates can know and respect your boundaries.

Formally design informal communications

> Sid Sijbrandij on Twitter/X

>

> When working remote it is important to formalize informal communication. Explicitly plan time to create, build, and maintain social connections and trust. In our handbook we list 15 methods <https://handbook.gitlab.com/informal-communication/> which I'll summarize in this thread.

Organize informal communication

Informal team member communications, such as a chat about life outside of work, are necessary for building trust. Trust is essential for great business results and is a foundational element of culture. Many businesses invest heavily in offices and facilities, because they believe offices are necessary for informal communication.

> During the pandemic, many businesses that were forced to work remotely discovered that productivity increased. Many of these same businesses are now making plans to return to the office. One reason given is that not everyone can work from home. GitLab solves this by allowing people to rent and expense work space. Another reason given is that people miss working from a central office with co-workers. I don't think that people miss the commute or the office furniture. They miss informal communication. Central offices are an expensive, inconvenient, and indirect way to facilitate informal communication. It is more efficient to directly organize informal communication.

>

> For example, every person who joins GitLab has to schedule at least 5 coffee chats during their onboarding. We also have Ask Me Anything meetings with senior leaders, Group calls organized by different groups/departments, and over 15 other explicit ways to encourage employee connections and relationship building. Intentionally organizing informal communication enables the trust-building conversations that are essential for collaboration. This can be more effective than relying on chance encounters in a physical office. You can connect with team members throughout the world and across departments through a coffee chat. You may not meet people outside of your own floor in an office setting. - GitLab co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij

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{{% card footer="Group social calls are a great way for remote teams to connect and bond" %}}

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Valuing conversation on non-work topics

Informal communication is important, as it enables friendships to form at work related to matters other than work. Those who feel they have genuine friends at work are more likely to enjoy their job, perform at a high level, feel invested in the company, and serve others within the organization. At GitLab, we desire those outcomes as well, reinforcing our Results value.

For all-remote companies, leaders should not expect informal communication to happen naturally. There are no hallways for team members to cross paths in, no carpools to the office, etc.

> If you do all-remote, do it early, do it completely, and change your work methods to accommodate it. Be intentional about informal communication. All-remote forces you to do the things you should be doing anyway, earlier. - GitLab co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij

In an all-remote environment, informal communication should be formally addressed. Leaders should organize informal communication, and to whatever degree possible, design an atmosphere where team members all over the globe feel comfortable reaching out to anyone to converse about topics unrelated to work.

Community impact outings

Community impact outings are a meaningful alternative to Zoom happy hours. Instead of allocating a shared hour to chat in a video call with teammates, consider a formal outing where each team member redirects that hour to their local community. This approach is not only more inclusive of time zones and family commitments (as the hour can be spent at any point in a given week versus a set time on a calendar), but it celebrates the core of what makes us all unique: our chosen homes and surroundings.

Here's how to construct a Community Impact Outing.

1. Ask your team to block a given amount of time (e.g. one hour) on their calendar during a specific week. Entitle it [TEAM] Community Impact Outing. Empower team members to devote time to something meaningful to them, such as volunteering at a library or assisting the elderly.
1. Optionally, ask team members to wear company swag during their outing and capture a photo, video, selfie, or written story.
1. At the start of the following week, encourage team members to share those assets in a team Slack channel, all-hands, or stand-up meeting. Dedicate time to sharing what each team member did and how it impacted them.

Empowering people to fill their social quota outside of work, in local neighborhoods and communities, and then bring that culture to work, creates a refreshing medium for fostering informal communication.

Create opportunity for chance meetings

> Sid Sijbrandij on Twitter/X

>

> Below is a thread about the future of remote work after the COVID-19 pandemic is over. I predict that remote will go through a trough of sorrow due to hybrid not working out, and most companies will return to being office based. But many all remote companies will see success.

In colocated settings, unplanned encounters can lead to interesting ideas or hypotheses, which

can sprout innovation. In remote settings, leadership should create opportunities for these "chance meetings" to still occur.

Remote retrospectives

Intentionally-organized remote retrospectives create an atmosphere of chance discussions, as you're specifically there to riff on something. Zoom supports Breakout Rooms, which may be useful in catalyzing such conversation.

Innovation communities

Encourage your workforce to join remote communities which exist to create chance meetings. Open Assembly is one such network, which "hosts the conversations, community and learning that help culture and business transition to the future of work." This creates a highly-focused session in which everyone arrives ready to engage with new people, find common ground, and share insights · all of which feed back into the culture and energy of one's workplace.

Conferences and events

Remote teams have a tendency to savor and anticipate in-person engagements. As in-person interactions are less common in a remote role, this presents an opportunity for leadership to maximize the utility of conferences and events.

Leaders should consider sending teams to conferences as an efficient way to organize a dense series of chance meetings, with each person then returning to saner spaces to process, distill, and put effort into newly seeded ideas.

The power of local communities

Global remote work creates tremendous opportunity for innovation to emerge from a more diverse array of locales. As remote teams are empowered to fill a part of their social quota by local interactions with neighbors and members of their home communities, they will experience a much richer set of inputs.

Consider a weekly asynchronous debrief where remote team members share lessons learned and challenges faced in their home communities, which may spark spin-off conversations within the workplace linked to new products or solutions.

Devote time to fostering relationships

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In all-remote environments, there should be a greater emphasis placed on carving out time to get to know one another as humans. To connect and bond as empathetic beings with interests, emotions, fears, and hopes · people, not just colleagues.

If you've spent any length of time in a corporate setting, you've probably seen a company institute a weekly or monthly "happy hour," designed to gather employees in a shared space to converse about topics unrelated to work.

For colocated companies, the occasional team offsite · to take in a sporting event, to enjoy a shared lunch, etc. · may be enough to supplement naturally occurring informal communication in the office.

Below are a number of intentional facets of GitLab's culture, created to foster informal communication. We welcome other all-remote companies to iterate on these and implement as desired.

1. Contribute Unconference: An in-person, week-long event where we bring the entire company together in one location to get to know each other better.
1. Coffee chats: More details below.
1. Coworking calls: More details below.
1. Social hours: Informal social calls organized within our immediate teams to get to know each other on a more personal level.
1. Local meetups: Co-located team members are encouraged to organize their own meetups, whether it's a coworking space or getting dinner together.
1. Slack: We use Slack channels for informal communications throughout the company, whether it's a team-specific channel or a channel dedicated to sharing vacation photos with other team members.
1. Zoom calls: Not only do we get to know our coworkers better by seeing them in real time during video calls, we also get to know their pets and families too. This visual engagement helps us relate to each other on a more personal level, so when we meet in person, we already know each other. In fact, when our team members meet face-to-face for the first time, the most surprising factor is usually each person's height.
1. Gaming: GitLab has a gaming Slack channel where fans of video games and digital board games can connect. Coordinating shared gaming sessions is a great way to informally connect with team members and collaborate toward goals outside of work.
1. Music making: GitLab's musicmaking Slack channel is a place where artists can come together and collaborate synchronously or asynchronously to make music together. Several GitLab team members came together to create All I Want This Quarter Is You (GitLab), a musical masterpiece on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.

> "I've been given a tour of team members' new houses, admired their Christmas decorations, squealed when their pets and kids make an appearance and watched them preparing dinner · glimpses into the personal lives of my colleagues that I've never had in any office job." - Rebecca, Managing Editor, GitLab

How can informal communication be improved?

In addition to all the ideas above, we've curated best practices for how to improve informal communication both as an individual and as a team.

Creating room for human connection on calls

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In a colocated setting, meetings tend to begin with personal conversation. Virtual calls may feel less amenable to that, so a team has to be intentional about creating space for empathy and human connection. A rolling calendar of calls that are purely about work can lead to burnout. At GitLab, we accomplish this through the following methods.

Speedy meetings

As part of our overall Communications Handbook, we prefer to utilize the "speedy meetings" setting in Google Calendar, which encourages before-the-call banter and conversation. It also provides space between meetings to recharge and reset.

Lead with empathy

Each work-related call should begin with an earnest, genuine "How are you?", or a similar and appropriate introduction. It's important to remember that everyone is facing a battle that you know nothing about, and in a remote setting you should actively listen.

Welcome interruptions in calls

We should welcome pets, children, deliveries, neighbors, or partners interrupting a call. This is an opportunity to bond and to humanize the work experience. Take a few minutes to talk to the person if they are open to it, or ask the team member to share more about their pets/family.

Using emoji to convey emotion

Though emoji have commonly been reserved for personal conversations that occur outside of the workplace, all-remote employees should feel comfortable using them in everyday discourse with team members.

Perception has shifted on using emoji in professional settings. In Slack alone, more than 26 million custom emoji have been created since the feature was introduced. In all-remote settings, where you may never meet a colleague in person, leveraging visual tools to convey nuance in tone, emphasis, and emotion can lead to more empathy and a tighter human connection.

> Using emoticons, emoji, and stickers can supplement the lack of human nonverbal cues in computer-mediated environment. The results show that proper use of emoticons, emoji, and stickers, especially positive emoticons, is conducive to both relationship formation and cognitive understanding. They not only help participants express emotions and manage interrelations but also function as words to aid message comprehension. - Ying Tang and Khe Foon Hew, researchers at the University of Hong Kong

Emoji can create a more inclusive communication environment. When you're working with colleagues where the de facto business language isn't someone's first language, more universal indicators (e.g. "eyes" for "I've seen this" or "smile" for positivity) can reduce the mental burden of deciphering a message.

Consider also using the Giphy Slack app to communicate. The app lets you search a library of animated GIFs and send them in Slack.

Talent shows

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Talent shows are great for building meaningful connections between colleagues, and are relatively easy to organize. Simply add a calendar invite, affix a Google Doc agenda to the invite for team members to sign up to showcase a talent, arrange a panel of 3-5 judges, and have a list of prizes ready to go.

If you organize these a week or two in advance, it enables team members to prepare. GitLab's Marketing team hosted a talent show on Zoom, with over 130 people on a video call. The moderator called on colleagues based on how they were arranged in the Google Doc, and the judges tallied up results at the end.

Virtual tour

During a coffee chat or a show and tell, take a moment to provide a virtual tour of where you live and work. This allows you to virtually "invite someone over" while enabling others to get to know you better. You can do this informally (while walking around with your laptop) or you can choose to make it a friendly competition within your team using recorded videos (à la Architectural Design's Open Door style).

This was done during the Threat Management sub-department's team day. They included a "Virtual Home Tour" as one of the activities and they recorded videos to share with the team (videos only available internally to GitLab).

Postcard swapping

Working in a truly global team means it's quite possible that nobody else works in your city. Sending postcards specific to your location to colleagues can be a great way to foster a sense of belonging and is usually very inexpensive. A group of GitLab team members set up a postcrossing Slack channel to swap addresses and send each other postcards from our home cities, towns and villages from around the world.

It can be a great way to learn about a new place that you may not know about and is a great source of conversation topics for coffee chats.

Examples:

1. Arty's postcards board
1. Manoj sending 30+ postcards to 12 different countries

Coffee chats

{{< youtube "CH-NHoBOeho?start=496" >}}

In the Traction Conference video above, GitLab co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij shares how remote teams can stay connected with Frederic Lardinois of TechCrunch.

We understand that working remotely leads to mostly work-related conversations with fellow team members, so everyone at GitLab is encouraged to dedicate a few hours a week to having social calls/coffee chats with anyone in the company.

It's a great chance to get to know who you work with, talk about everyday things and share a coffee, tea, or your favorite beverage. We want you to make friends and build relationships with the people you work with to create a more comfortable, well-rounded environment.

Scheduling a Coffee Chat

GitLab Team Members can easily schedule a Coffee Chat in Google Calendar and link it to Zoom, with a 1-click link to the video call. When scheduling coffee chats with executive leadership, please reach out to their EBA to find a mutually available time. If they are not on the list in the EBA Handbook, please follow the steps below:

Watch this short video to see how it's done.

1. Search for the person in Google Calendar
1. Choose the time and duration (25 minutes is common for a coffee chat).
1. Name the meeting Name / Name coffee-chat
1. Click on Make it a Zoom meeting

Google Calendar will warn you if the time is outside the other person's working hours, and you can select from a list of suggested times.

Diversifying your Coffee Chats

Coffee Chats are a fantastic opportunity to intentionally broaden your perspective at GitLab. Some suggestions on intentional Coffee Chats:

1. Pair with someone in a group/stage that have some overlap with yours, but with whom you don't interact regularly.
1. Pair with someone in a group/stage that your team has dependencies with, but that you don't know well (for example, Customer Success + Customer Support).
1. Pair with someone from a different region of the world (being respectful of working hours).
1. Pair with someone complementary to you · for example, if you're new, find someone who's been here a while; if you're in marketing, pair with a developer; and so on.

You can use the GitLab org chart, Product stages page, or Team page to find team members to pair with.

Leadership Coffee Chat with URG Team Members

At the CEOs request, as of 2021-03-01 we are launching an effort Leadership Coffee Chats with URG Team Members aimed at driving more conversations and increasing understanding between

leadership and Underrepresented Groups (URGs). Our goal is to leverage every opportunity to increase allyship and engage with all URGs at GitLab. The first iteration will start with our Black team members. Future iterations will include Coffee Chats with LatinX, Asian, LGBTQ, Women, etc. Anything discussed will remain confidential.

This format is similar to our regular Coffee Chats, and in this first iteration, the E-Group and the All-Directs layer of leadership will connect with Black team members for coffee chats. To start, we will keep these within the same function as much as possible (i.e. Black team member in Marketing invited for a Coffee Chat with the CMO and an All-Direct Leader in Marketing)

The coffee chats are optional for our Black team members and participation is opt-in. Leaders and EBA's will drive this engagement by scheduling coffee chats with each of you who have opted in. You will opt-in via the spreadsheet titled Leadership Coffee Chat with URG (Black) which is searchable in Google Drive and clicking the checkbox in column C. URG team members should feel no pressure opt-in as this is optional. If you are unable to participate and you'd like to join a future coffee chat, please ping the Staff EBA to the CEO in slack in eba-team to be added to the spreadsheet.

We recognize that coffee chats may place pressure on the URG team member to come up with questions or topics for the call to help alleviate that, we've started a list of conversation starters below that can be used during the coffee chat, these are purely suggestions that can be deviated from:

1. Tell me about yourself

1. What's the most exciting thing you're working on lately?

1. If you had to pick any character in a book, movie, or TV show who is most similar to you, who would you choose? Why?

1. When you were growing up, what was your dream job? Is any part of that still true?

1. What is your biggest regret? or fear?

1. What has been the best thing about working at GitLab?

1. If you had to pick one skydiving, bungee jumping, or scuba diving which would you do?

1. Which of your family members are you most like? Why?

1. If you had a reality TV show about your life, what would your theme song be?

1. What would an even more joyful workplace culture look like to you?

1. What are 5-10 qualities that you think are must-haves for new hires in terms of culture fit?

1. Which company value would you like to have a new high mark in? (as in, which do you feel you aren't living to its potential?)

1. If you could choose a colleague, team member, or exemplary professional to coach you on a particular topic, who would it be and why?

1. When do you have the most fun at work?

1. What or who inspired you this week? How?

1. How have you improved your remote working skills this month? Have you identified any challenges?

1. What are your primary goals this quarter?

1. What is the most meaningful part of your job?

1. What would you change about our product if you had a magic wand?

1. How do you describe our offering to family and friends?

1. What opportunities for learning and growth have you recently found or created for yourself?

What such opportunities do you see for your colleagues?

If you have any questions please reach out to the Staff EBA to the CEO or the Manager, Diversity Inclusion and Belonging or your People Business Partner. If your question/feedback can be posted publicly, please post in the slack channel urg-leadership-coffee-chat

The Donut Bot

Team members can join the donutbestrangers Slack channel to be paired with a random team member for a coffee chat. The "Donut" bot will automatically send a message to two people in the channel every other Monday.

Please schedule a chat together, and Donut will follow up for feedback.

You can also directly reach out to your fellow GitLab team members to schedule a coffee chat in the donutbestrangers Slack channel or via direct message.

In the year 2020, Donut reported 537 people connected through 2042 coffee chats at GitLab, compared to 367 chats in similar-sized companies.

In the year 2021, Donut reported 846 people connected through 3210 coffee chats at GitLab, compared to 372 chats in similar-sized companies.

In the year 2022, Donut reported 1265 people connected through 4186 coffee chats at GitLab, compared to 356 chats in similar-sized companies.

GitLab Team Member Mixer Calls

Similar to a coffee chat, a "GitLab Team Member Mixer" call aims to help team members meet more folks from other groups or functions that they might not otherwise get to spend a lot of time working or interfacing with.

To set up a GitLab Team Member Mixer, two team members set up a single Zoom line. Using the single Zoom line, each of those team members invites someone else to join - making a total of four team members on the call. This way, you'll get to meet someone new - or find connections between team members you didn't know existed. Each "host" brings a topic to discuss in case the conversation needs help getting started.

At the end - the host and their co-host's guest set up another GitLab Team Member Mixer call - with two new guests. In this way, the participation gets spread throughout the organization and connects as many team members as possible.

Juice Box Chats

Similar to a coffee chat, a "Juice Box Chat" is a chance for GitLab team members and their children, grandchildren, or other members of their family to get to know one another as well. These chats can be informal or can focus on a specific topic: Legos, Super Heroes, camping, and video games all make for great subjects.

As we work in an all-remote environment, kids and other household members often show up to calls unannounced, which is just part of working remotely. However, Juice Box Chats allow us to meet and socialize this way intentionally. Think a "bring your kid to work day" except in an all-remote company.

You can take a look at the internal time zones and interests document to find a group that might work for you or join our kid-juicebox-chats channel in Slack.

Team Days and Social Calls

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Some teams at GitLab organize informal social calls on a regular basis in order to build camaraderie.

The data team has them every Tuesday.

Team members and managers are encouraged to create these calls as a medium for informal, agenda-free interaction between team members.

Team days are another opportunity to intermix work and rapport building, and can be structured to work synchronously or asynchronously.

Show and Tell

Consider creating a shared calendar for social events to more broadly allow people to join and be aware of social events that are in a more convenient time zone. For example, GitLab's marketing team has a "Show and Tell" call where team members are encouraged to display something they've crafted and share the story behind it.

Arranging this is simple. Send a calendar invite to a team or department with a shared document attached. Those interested in showing can sign up in a numerical list with their names, so that it's simple to hop from one person to the next on the eventual video call.

Show and Tell sessions are excellent ways to humanize the work experience, and to learn about colleagues on a deeper, more personal level. It showcases what they're proud of, and what provides fulfillment outside of work.

Team DJ Zoom Room

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Zoom added a unique feature within its Share Screen function, enabling a remote team to share audio from their computer with all who are in the Zoom meeting. This is useful for getting an entire team together in a shared virtual space without everyone feeling compelled to speak and socialize. A shared DJ Room is ideal for scenarios where team members need to be mostly heads-down on work, but appreciate the closeness of the team and the shared musical experience.

To create additional interaction, hand off the proverbial DJ duties every 2-3 songs, enabling

an array of team members to share their favorite tunes. This can trigger fun conversation on preferred music genres and artists

To utilize this feature in Zoom, see below.

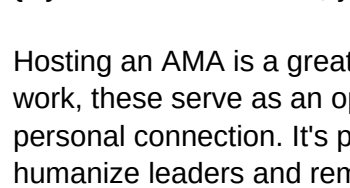
- Click the upward arrow beside the Share Screen icon
- Click the Advanced option tab at the top of the screen
- Click Music or Computer Sound Only
- Play music from any app or website, being mindful that you'll want to lower the volume so that your voice can also be heard

More instructions on this can be found at this support page.

Create a company songbook

If the Team DJ Zoom Room strikes a proverbial chord with your team, consider creating a company songbook. Get inspired by visiting the GitLab Songbook.

AMA (Ask Me Anything)

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Hosting an AMA is a great way for people to learn about others. While questions can be about work, these serve as an opportunity to ask funny and far-fetched questions that enable a more personal connection. It's particularly important to consider ongoing AMAs with executives. AMAs humanize leaders and remind teams that we are all more alike than we are unlike.

Celebrations and holidays

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A team that is distributed across the globe creates opportunity for many celebrations. Different countries and cultures celebrate in their own way, enabling team members to gain an understanding of key dates and events that matter to colleagues. A culture that encourages a team to thoughtfully express their celebrations on company calls is a healthy, inclusive one.

Global pizza parties/meals

Teams can also arrange shared meals around the world. Global pizza parties, for example, are possible to document and enjoy in a shared setting (Zoom or Slack), though one may wish to consider a breakfast pizza depending on time zone.

Social games

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You can now bring peers or colleagues into online game shows through platforms like Luna Park. Some social games are built for synchronous experiences like Collab, while on-demand games are more amenable to asynchronous engagement across time zones.

Virtual lunch table

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An easy way to create an opportunity for team members to connect over a virtual meal is to maintain a videoconference room that serves as a rolling lunch table.

Adventurous team members could even cook on camera, and the host may consider utilizing Zoom's Share Music feature to pipe music into the virtual gathering spot.

Sharing a meal is a powerful way to connect as humans, particularly when you open it up globally. This creates a more casual atmosphere where team members can connect with colleagues on a more personal level, without work at the center of the video call.

Virtual scavenger hunt

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{{% card footer="Virtual scavenger hunt at GitLab" %}}

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GitLab's Customer Success team ideated and executed a worldwide scavenger hunt using GitLab (the product), which is detailed on the GitLab Unfiltered blog and is easily replicated.

Virtual trivia

GitLab's global marketing team plays pub-style trivia every other week. You can compete as individuals or as teams, with a suggested time of 1 hour. For those within the GitLab organization, email events@gitlab.com if you want to arrange a game for your team.

GitLab utilizes MysteryTrip, which serves large teams well and doesn't place a heavy preparation load on the organizer. MysteryTrip handles the preparation work for questions, acts as trivia master, and has automatic scoring and a leadercard. This makes spinning up a game quick and easy, with pricing set at around \$20 per player. For those outside of the GitLab organization, regularly-scheduled trivia sessions are an excellent way to take everyone's focus away from work and engage in a shared experience.

Co-working calls

These video calls are scheduled working sessions on Zoom where team members can work through challenging tasks with a coworker, or simply hang out while each person works on their own tasks.

This recreates a productive working session you might have in person in a traditional office setting, but from the comfort of your own desk.

Want to try advanced mode? Screen share as you work together (keeping in mind any confidentiality issues).

Collaborative virtual quizzes

A collaborative quiz tool like Kahoot can be used for virtual team-building activities. Split into smaller breakout groups on Zoom to get to know each other and answer the questions. When you come back together in the central session, you can go over the questions and share stories about the answers. Incorporate some friendly competition by offering a prize for the winners.

Humanizing the digital experience

In the wake of COVID-19, many suddenly-remote companies are seeking to humanize the digital experience. For companies which were not intentional about structuring informal communication in an office, this void becomes glaring in a remote environment.

In this section, we'll spotlight tips and advice from other experts and companies.

Bretton Putter, founder at CultureGene, shares the below examples.

- 1. Book, TV, and movie clubs
- 1. Movie nights leveraging Netflix Party
- 1. Group game/dance/music nights via a streaming service like Twitch
- 1. Lunch and Learn webinars (ideally learning about something not directly work related, such as playing an instrument)
- 1. Group fitness, yoga, and meditation sessions
- 1. Conference call bingo
- 1. Regular team coffee break rooms
- 1. Collaborative quizzes
- 1. Green/yellow/red personal status check-ins
- 1. Geekbot "What I Did This Weekend" polls for teams on Slack
- 1. Dress-up/hat themes for team or all-hands video calls

Tools for building empathy and connection

- 1. Build empathy, rapport, and cohesion on remote teams with Kona by Sike Insights
- 1. Asynchronous voice messaging for teams via Yac
- 1. Asynchronous video messaging for teams via Loom

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Informal Communication in an All-Remote Environment

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation certification to receive the Remote Foundations Badge in GitLab Learn. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/internship.md

On this page, we're detailing considerations for both employee and employer as it relates to remote internships (also referred to as apprenticeships and co-ops).

What are the benefits of remote internships?

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There are many reasons why remote internships are a value-add to any organization.

Competitive hiring advantage

Remote is the future of work. The ability to learn and work from wherever one is most fulfilled will soon become the norm. Companies which are built to support remote work (e.g. firms which create digital products), yet refuse to offer such flexibility, will be in low demand by top talent. This includes the most promising interns.

Offering remote internships provides a competitive advantage to attracting ambitious and capable interns, but it will soon diminish into a practical requirement.

Diversity

By hiring remote interns, organizations are able to broaden their usual scope and recruit talent from underserved areas of the globe. Cultural and geographic diversity is important to long-term success and vibrancy in a company.

Fresh perspective

Interns are capable of offering valuable perspective. Given that many are only working for a few months, they're able to evaluate an organization with fresh eyes, and they have little to lose by offering transparent feedback along the way.

Particularly for interns who are in university, or recently graduated, they may also bring new tools and methodologies to the table.

Finding a remote internship

Remote internships are more common than ever, though finding them can be challenging. Below, we're highlighting destinations that feature remote internships, where employers can post and job seekers can apply.

- Covintern

- RemoteOK

What makes a remote internship different?

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Remote internships are unique in one primary way: there is no physical office involved. The rough timeline for an internship · 3 to 6 months · is typically the same in a remote internship as it is in most colocated internships. Internships are where working baselines are formed, and conducting one remotely requires special care and consideration from everyone involved.

This is of particular importance given that interns are usually inexperienced in the workplace. Internships have historically been used to introduce people to the working world. Foundational communication skills are learned in internships, as are conventions, norms, and expectations. They serve as an opportunity for an intern to ask a multitude of questions, given that practically everything about the experience is new.

What are the drawbacks of remote internships?

Like any remote-working situation, remote internships have multiple advantages, but remote work doesn't suit everyone. Depending on their lifestyle, work preferences, and drive, a remote internship can have disadvantages as well. We have outlined potential challenges and solutions for remote internships in our all remote guide [here](#).

Employer considerations

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It is unlikely that an intern will be equipped to be a manager of one, and companies should expect interns to require a great deal of hand-holding.

Learn more about the importance of clear communication, intentional onboarding, and utilizing asynchronous workflows in a Harvard Business School article entitled "[Best practices for creating a successful virtual internship](#)."

What are the best practices for managing a remote internship?

Managing a remote internship is similar to managing one in-person. We've created an in-depth guide to being a great remote manager which includes focusing on:

- Self-awareness for relationship building
- Employing empathy and kindness
- Overcoming ego to be a servant-leader
- Communicating in great detail
- Modeling trustworthiness

What are the best tools for managing a remote internship?

Remote internships are fertile ground for communication breakdowns. Intentionally prioritizing strong communication lines, creating a psychologically safe space for interns to learn, and hiring the right interns will ensure a positive and successful experience.

Creating good communication

There is much to glean from GitLab's approach to meetings, and a well-organized internship will also incorporate communication strategies such as scheduled AMAs, group conversations, and Key Reviews.

Creating psychological safety

In colocated settings, interns can be physically sat beside a mentor, ready and able to answer a stream of questions throughout the internship period. The physical proximity typically creates psychological safety for the intern, enabling them to ask questions as they arise without an overarching fear that they are imposing.

To thrive, remote team members must appreciate and respect autonomy, though this requires a certain sophistication for self-searching and self-learning.

Interns who are inexperienced in the working world may be hesitant to ask questions in a remote setting. Some may feel that a constant stream of Slack pings or Zoom requests are a bother to their mentor. The virtual wall may create a friction point as they assume that everyone is busy and unreachable, and in turn, their blockers cannot be addressed.

Employers should act proactively to address this. Consider the following.

1. Have mentors and/or managers checking in with remote interns on a regular cadence, at least once per hour.
1. Reiterate daily that interns are free to inquire as often as necessary, as if their mentor were in the same physical room.
1. Host an "always-on" video room where the intern is able to see at least one other person working. (Note that this may require an overview of all-remote meeting nuances.)
1. Assign interns a second monitor where "always-on" video rooms can be present, overcoming the awkwardness of a standing video meeting.

Hiring remote interns

There are certain qualities that hiring teams look for in remote hires at any level. These include an appreciation for self-learning and self-service, a penchant for documentation, and a proven ability to work asynchronously.

Interns will naturally lack the work experience required to have a great grasp for any of the above; however, hiring teams can ask certain questions that provide insight into how they've operated in remote settings outside of the workplace.

Consider the following questions.

1. Tell me about a time when you moved a group project forward, at work or school, where you were in a different physical place than your other team members? (Particularly for university

students, chances are high that they have worked remotely on an important project. Dig for details on how they enjoyed it, what challenges they faced, and how they coped.)

1. Have you ever taken an online course or training session? If so, describe your process for managing your own time, respecting deadlines, requesting assistance, and solving problems.

1. Are you an active member of an online community, or do you have experience managing logistics remotely for in-person events/gatherings?

1. Have you completed freelance work for remote clients, and would you be willing to provide references upon request?

1. Have you thought about where you would work remotely if offered this internship? (Managers should not expect a precise answer to this, as even senior staff should experiment with workspaces, but it's useful to understand if the candidate has considered this element.)

Length of internship

While 3-month internships are common in colocated settings, consider offering 4-month remote internships. The added month creates space to acclimate to working remotely.

In-person fast boots

While not necessarily required, organizations should consider a week-one in-person onboarding session - particularly if hiring several interns as part of a cohort.

A final week of in-person interaction may be useful for retrospectives and potential next steps.

What are the challenges of managing a remote internship?

Because remote internships are learning-based and fast-paced, there are some red flags to watch out for:

- Loneliness and isolation--be sure to set up a regular communication schedule with your intern/s.
- Feeling left out--be sure to create ways for your intern/s to connect with both you and the team.
- Overworking--be sure to model and encourage work/life boundaries.

Managing expectations

It's important for organizations to remember that remote interns are essentially learning two fundamental things: the job itself, and how to work well with no office. In turn, it's important to calibrate expectations and what is measured.

This may be particularly challenging in fast-paced all-remote settings. All-remote companies tend to be highly efficient. In a firm where impact, not activity, are measured, there is a natural inclination to expect expediency. When a remote intern is learning two major lessons at once, progress may feel slower than usual.

For organizations with a strong desire to use their remote internship program as an intern-to-hire mechanism, be sure to screen for this during the interview process. Encourage prospective interns to be transparent about their intentions and readiness to start if successful.

Mentorship training program

Firms hiring remote interns should first conduct training programs with managers. Touch on areas such as empathy for being junior, and enlist a trainer who can put the senior manager into the shoes of a new intern. This will prepare managers and mentors to think through questions and concerns from interns, and remind them of what it's like to be inexperienced and nervous when entering a new workplace.

Offer remote mentors

Remote interns may be operating in their very first remote role. Organizations should not expect them to simply know how to work well in a remote setting. While GitLab's guide to starting a remote role may be of assistance, there are many assumptions made that require workplace experience.

Consider a secondary mentor for the length of the internship that has a great deal of experience in remote settings. Veteran remote workers are experts in sensing struggles and offering solutions by those who are struggling to thrive outside of an office.

Remember: struggling remote interns may have a sound understanding of their work tasks, but are unable to articulate blockers related to their work environment.

Consider also creating opportunities for interns to connect and network with senior leaders on the team. In his session at REMOTE by GitLab, Professor Raj Choudhury shared the results of a Harvard Business School study showing how brief virtual water cooler sessions with senior managers might have job and career benefits for newcomers in a remote setting. Watch the recording to learn more:

{{< youtube "RVMUworx2Vk" >}}

Select projects intentionally

Certain projects and tasks are more easily completed by junior staff. Moreover, certain tasks are more easily accomplished asynchronously.

Leaders should be careful to not offload their own energy vampires on remote interns, but rather select complete projects that an intern can start and finish in a few months.

Too, it's important to select projects which are important or notable to a large group. This ensures that many people in the organization are invested in the intern's success, and it widens the scope of available mentors who are knowledgeable about the project and can step in and help across time zones.

If possible, avoid time critical work. Great intern projects tend to be items which are largely seen as "nice to haves" by full-time staff. These are projects that everyone recognizes would benefit the organization, but do not rise to the level of priority necessary to demand senior staff attention.

Make your strategy and onboarding public

At GitLab, we make our strategy and OKRs (objectives and key results) public, and offer copious context on the question of "What's it like to work at GitLab?" This shows respect for job seekers, and it ensures that those who apply resonate with our values.

Hiring remote interns is hard. An organization shouldn't make it harder by concealing their vision and values until after an intern is hired. Given the remarkably short duration of the internship experience, it's vital to act transparently in order to create as much pre-start alignment as possible.

How can interns make the most of a remote internship?

Interns must recognize that expectations for self-managing your time will likely be higher in a remote internship, while resources may be fewer if a company lacks a mature internship infrastructure.

It's important to ask questions during the interview phase to understand the work environment. You'll want to make sure you have a remote mentor or onboarding buddy who will be available to answer questions related to working remotely.

Too, consider reading GitLab's guide to evaluating a remote job and ask relevant questions as you interview.

All-remote forces you to do things that you should do anyway, but more quickly and more intentionally. That's a great backdrop for remote interns, who stand to gain not only work experience, but experience working in an environment where you're in control of your space, your time, and your approach.

What are the best ways to stay connected with remote interns?

If you don't hire your remote intern/s at the end of their internship experience, be sure to sweeten their transition out by ending well.

1. Say Thanks for the work they contributed during their internship. At GitLab, we even have a thanks Slack channel!

1. Acknowledge intern contributions in team meetings, issues, company calls, 1-1 meetings.

1. Send a gift or a swag bag to commemorate their contributions.

Don't forget to gather information they are willing to share such as their email address, LinkedIn profile, or handles for other social channels so you can stay in touch. Who knows...maybe a position at GitLab will come available that you can hire them for!

Contribute your lessons

GitLab is currently piloting an engineering internship program. We expect to learn a great deal from the experience, while documenting challenges and solutions. If you or your organization has experience offering remote internships which would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/interviews.md

On this page, we're addressing a popular question: "How do you interview remotely?" We're also curating a list of questions that we at GitLab appreciate hearing answers to from others in remote organizations.

How do you interview remotely?

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Whether you're wanting to learn how to hire remotely, or just wanting to know how to get hired for a remote position, it helps to know how you should prepare for a remote interview. You only get one chance to make a first impression, so keep these tips in mind.

How do you prepare for a remote interview?

Remote interviews are similar to in-person interviews in many ways: You're still trying to make a good impression and communicate your strengths, you're just not doing it from the same room. One thing is certain: preparation is just as important in a remote interview as an in-person interview.

1. Read instructions from your interviewer carefully (and ask questions if something is unclear). Make sure that you understand the requirements for the interview and follow them carefully. The best way to make a good first impression is simply to be well-prepared!
1. Prepare yourself with notes. An advantage of having a remote interview is that you can make a "cheat sheet" for anything you want to mention, questions you'd like to ask, or other information that will help you get the most from the conversation.
1. Have a distraction-free area for the interview, if possible. Background noise or clutter can take attention away from you, which is not what you want.
1. Make eye contact. Look into the camera as much as possible, not the screen.
1. Have a practice meeting. If it will help you feel more comfortable, try to download any software for a video call far enough in advance to test your audio and video settings.
1. Don't browse on your computer or phone during an interview. Only have what you need for the interview, and don't get distracted.
1. Use headphones with a microphone. Not only will this make you sound better, it will reduce listening fatigue for the other person as well so that you can have a better conversation.

What technology do you need to participate in and manage a remote interview?

Camera

For a remote interview, being able to easily navigate a video call is vital. First, consider how you want to present yourself visually by choosing a camera quality:

1. Inbuilt webcam on a phone, laptop, or external display (baseline)
1. Dedicated USB webcam (mid-tier)
1. Mirrorless camera or DSLR with dedicated lens (high-end)

Headphones

Wearing headphones can create a more positive video experience for all. If you're using a dedicated microphone, you may prefer comfortable studio-style headphones without an in-line mic. If you want to reduce the amount of hardware you're using, headphones with an in-line mic will be more appropriate.

Some prefer in-ear headphones rather than over-the-head headphones, and it's important to consider long-term comfortability for those who may find themselves in video calls for multiple hours per day.

Bluetooth headphones can be problematic due to limitations of microphone quality, latency, and battery life. If you opt for Bluetooth headphones, it is recommended that you use a separate wired microphone. Bluetooth headsets can easily jump between devices, thus it is recommended to only pair one set per device to avoid unexpected disconnects during video calls.

Microphones

"When audio quality is high (vs low), people judge the content as better and more important. They also judge the speaker as more intelligent, competent, and likable. Messages that are difficult to process are less compelling." This research, conducted by Norbert Schwarz at the University of Southern California, reinforces the importance of investing in equipment and atmosphere to generate the highest-fidelity audio in a remote setting.

When possible, avoid doing a job interview in a room with other people or in a place with heavy background noise. If you have a pair of Bluetooth or wired earbuds with an in-line microphone (like the ones commonly included with most smartphones), use those instead of the built-in microphone of a laptop, phone, or desktop monitor. These microphones tend to be of low quality, and do little to stop background noise.

Reliable internet

You can have great technology, but if you fail to connect or stay connected during your interview, it can make it difficult to have a productive conversation. Be sure to reset, check, and test your internet connection especially prior to an interview.

If you have challenges with connectivity in your home office, consider asking your interviewer or recruiter whether the company offers interview accommodations such as reimbursing the cost to rent a private office or call booth for the interview.

How do you conduct a remote interview?

Conducting a remote interview is all about preparation, and most importantly, setting expectations for the person being interviewed. You also have technical considerations to make since the person joining the video/conference call is using a different setup than you, or they may not have interviewed remotely before. Be clear about how to join the interview and the technical requirements. Make sure the process and/or email templates are documented internally so that others can communicate this process to future interviewees.

1. Specify if it is a phone or video interview. Nothing can derail the interview faster than

being caught offguard. Communicate this ahead of time.

1. Give instructions for how to connect to the video call. Include download instructions for the software you're using or a step-by-step guide if connecting from the web.

1. Give the candidate an outline. The team at FlexJobs recommends an outline with an interview start time, the name of the interviewer and anyone else they will be meeting, and the general order of events so they know when to speak.

1. Have a practice meeting. Use this opportunity to make sure your audio and video is coming through clearly.

1. Have questions prepared and in front of you ahead of time. Owl Labs has prepared this list of remote questions if you need some inspiration.

1. Share the process and documentation with others. Make templates and processes available to other interviewers so that everyone communicates effectively.

How can you make a remote interview feel more personal?

Posture

Before a remote interview, check your front-facing camera or webcam to ensure you are well lit and can be seen. Maintain eye contact with your screen/camera and allow yourself to smile and react naturally--the same way you would for an in-person interview.

Place

Pick a neutral location that is quiet and comfortable. That way, neither you nor the interviewer will be distracted by your environment. We encourage you to display your quirkiness and personality, but for an interview, it's best to avoid chaos.

Practice

To help make a great first impression, prepare by researching the company and reviewing their handbook and values. Practice answering some sample interview questions live with a peer or by recording yourself or practicing in a mirror.

What traits do remote interviewers look for?

In an all-remote organization, each individual is empowered to work and live where they are most fulfilled.

During the interview phase, it's vital to get an understanding of how a potential employee understands and plans to participate effectively in remote work. To be a great remote worker, potential hires should be:

- able to work asynchronously
- self-disciplined and able to be a manager of one
- comfortable with remote communication, much of which is communicated through text
- ready to engineer an optimal workspace
- able to focus and pinpoint both when and where you prefer to work on a daily basis
- prepared to create work/life boundaries and balance in a work from anywhere scenario

What are some tips for succeeding in a remote interview?

Showcase your remote expertise

With many companies embracing remote work and hiring remotely, it's important to highlight your remote skills just like you would your other qualifications for the role. You can certainly incorporate this into the interview process, but you also may want to consider updating your resume.

The team at We Work Remotely addressed the question, "Should your resume change after the pandemic?" in an Instagram post with these five tips:

1. Showcase remote work skills: Don't only focus on tools, explain how you've been able to collaborate online, and how comfortable you are with asynchronous communication. If you transitioned to remote work, explain how you did it successfully!

1. Focus on the results you've brought to your past jobs: When your boss and coworkers can't see you, the only thing they can know about your work is the results you produce. Add what you've been able to accomplish in the past, numbers and processes are important to mention.

1. Don't be afraid to explain more if you have work gaps: The pandemic resulted in many jobs lost. If you lost your job or had to quit for personal reasons, it's important to explain it (as long as you're comfortable). Take this as an opportunity to explain if you learned something during this time, if you leveled up a skill, or if you worked on side projects.

1. Show that you're more than just a worker: Things have changed and companies are interested in knowing that you have a life outside of work. Add your interests or hobbies to your resume.

Bonus points if you can explain how those help you be a better worker.

1. Keep your location general, or tweak it depending on the job you're applying to: Your complete address is irrelevant, get rid of it! If the job you're applying to requires a specific location or time zone, be sure to add it to your resume.

What are the benefits of conducting a remote interview?

Remote interviews expand the possibilities for recruiting a more diverse and inclusive workforce. Remote gives your company a competitive advantage by opening the recruiting pipeline to unlimited geographic regions and sourcing employees from any location.

Not only does this create a more competitive hiring process by reaching a more diverse set of candidates, but it also allows your organization to hire great people not limited by the basis of salary.

What are the challenges of conducting a remote interview?

For hiring teams, one of the most common challenges associated with remote interviews is gaining insight into the candidate's personali